

USD 492, FLINTHILLS SCHOOL DISTRICT

RISK FACTORS FOR YOUTH SUICIDE

Risk factors for suicide refer to personal, social, physical, or cultural characteristics that are associated with suicide. Individuals affected by one or more of these risk factors may have a greater probability of suicidal behavior. There is no single, agreed-upon list of risk factors, but this page summarizes the risk factors identified by current research.



Behavioral Health Issues/Disorders

- Depressive disorders
- Substance abuse (alcohol and other drugs)
- Conduct/disruptive behavior disorders
- Other mental health diagnoses
- Previous suicide attempts
- Self-injury (without the intent to die)
- Genetic/biological vulnerability (mainly abnormalities in serotonin functioning, which can lead to some of the behavioral health problems listed above)



Personal Characteristics

- Hopelessness
- Low self-esteem
- Loneliness
- Social alienation and isolation
- Experience of low belonging
- Low stress and frustration tolerance
- Impulsivity
- Risk-taking or reckless behaviors
- Poor problem solving or coping skills
- Negative perception of self or self-image
- Capacity to self-injure
- Perception of being a burden (e.g., to family or friends)



Adverse/Stressful Life Circumstances

- Interpersonal difficulties or losses (e.g., breaking up with a partner)
- Disciplinary or legal problems
- Bullying, either as a victim or perpetrator
- School or work problems
- Physical, sexual, and/or psychological abuse
- Chronic physical illness or disability
- Exposure to suicide of a peer



Risk-Taking Behaviors

- Alcohol or drug use
- Delinquency
- Aggressive/violent behavior
- Risky sexual behavior
- Reckless driving
- Putting self in dangerous situations on purpose



Family Characteristics

- Family history of suicide or suicidal behavior
- Parental or caregiver mental health problems
- Death of a caregiver or relative
- Caregiver divorce
- Problems in caregiver-child relationship (e.g., feelings of detachment, communication issues, interpersonal conflicts, financial struggles, violence of abuse, highly critical caregivers)



Environmental Factors

- Negative social and emotional environment at school, including negative attitudes, beliefs, feelings, and interactions with staff/students
- Lack of acceptance of differences
- Expressions and acts of hostility
- Lack of respect and fair treatment
- Lack of respect for cultures of all students
- Limitations in school physical environment, including lack of safety and security
- Poorly lit areas conducive to bullying and violence
- Limited access to mental health care
- Access to lethal means, particularly at home
- Exposure to other suicides
- Exposure to stigma and discrimination against students based on race, ethnicity, sex, ability, sexual orientation, gender identity, or physical appearance

